eventually left Earth again on January 16th, 2003, aboard the *Columbia* with six other astronauts. The launch was successful except that a piece of the shuttle's foam insulation broke apart from the body of the ship and hit the left wing of the spacecraft. The crew spent its time in space conducting natural experiments and documenting the effects of space travel on the human body. Their return to Earth was just a few weeks later, on February 1st, but due to its previous damage, the shuttle became unstable during its reentry into the atmosphere and broke apart. Chawla and her fellow crew members were killed, leading to the grounding of the space shuttle program for several years afterward. Just days after the accident, India's prime minister, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, renamed the space program's meteorological series of satellites "Kalpana-1."

In the years following the *Columbia* disaster, manned-space missions were put on hold, but ISRO was far from idle. Intensive research went into satellite technology, rockets, capsule recovery, troubleshooting, and much, much more. In 2013, India sent an orbiter to Mars, an important step that put their program on par with similar departments of America's National Aeronautics and Space Administration. Not only had ISRO run the same successful mission as NASA, but they'd done it for ten times less money. In an industry where projects always carry a hefty price tag, the ability to put together high-quality, low-cost equipment is truly revolutionary.

The wins kept on coming in the 2010s for India's space program. In 2016, ISRO sent 28 satellites into orbit from Indonesia, Germany, the United States, and Canada. And three years before this, in 2013, they had created their own satellite navigation system—the IRNSS. The Indian Regional Navigation Satellite System was developed to give India's scientists and astronauts primary access to satellite navigation systems instead of relying on the cooperative use of systems run by other nations. The precedent for such technology was set in 1999 when India and Pakistan engaged in armed conflict following the discovery of disguised Pakistani military insurgents crossing the border in Kashmir. The skirmish lasted two months, during which time ISRO was refused access to the American satellite navigation system.

India's space program continues on doggedly, expanding rather than shrinking as many other national space programs did after the initial excitement of the moon landing. By 2022, ISRO hopes to start sending